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A Desire for Unity Achieved Through Hatred

‘Ko pijeva, zlo ne misli’. Those who sing, don’t mean evil.

Yugoslavia was a country where the East kissed the West, where layered histories of empire, religion, culture, and class converged with modern ideals of consumerism and mass media. Positioned geopolitically between the two dominant power blocs of the twentieth century, Yugoslavia existed in a deliberate state of in-between, neither fully communist nor capitalist, but instead cultivating a unique socialist identity that borrowed from both. This duality was not only political or economic; it permeated everyday life, shaping aesthetics, values, and modes of cultural expression. Music was one of the most evident exhibitions of these ideals, and “it was logical that the sphere of musical taste didn’t stay politically neutral after Tito’s death” (Slavkova 424). Under the Milosevic regime, there was a rise in nationalism which plagued the music industry with hatred disguised in “tacky, high-octane techno with melodies based loosely on traditional Balkan folk music” (Cvoro 1). This new genre became known as “TurboFolk.” It was highly associated with Serbian nationalism, was often financed by the mafia, and served “as the soundtrack to some of the most heinous war crimes since the Holocaust” (Cvoro 1).

Prior to the TurboFolk takeover of Serbia, Rock and Roll dominated the region. Two of the most influential artists from the mid-seventies onward were Bijelo Dugme (White Button) and Plavi Orkestar (Blue Orchestra). Bijelo Dugme formed in 1974 in Sarajevo, and their music

and ideas focused on improving Yugoslavia politically. Frontman Goran Bregovic believed that the change the country required after Tito's death was in the "frame of mind and a loosening of the ideological rigidness characteristic of the ruling party" (Misina 200). He accurately foresaw that by casting all anticommunists as far-right nationalists, "Croats will start hating Serbs and Serbs Croats'" (Misina 199). Within a rigid system that didn't allow for a middle ground – an evolution to communism – the tension would build until a breaking point.

Plavi Orkestar released their breakout album in 1984, also in Sarajevo, and focused on uniting people through cultural changes in a post-Tito Yugoslavia. A strong unifier of the ex-Yugoslav states was a shared disdain for Fascism. So songs such a "Fa Fa Fasista," with lyrics loosely translating to "Fa Fa Fascist Don't be you, Because I will, Dear, kill you" (Lošić), were meant to warn people of the increasingly heterogeneous socio-cultural elements of Yugoslavia that were mimicking the common enemy, Fascists. Both bands would agree that "since the political and cultural foundations of Yugoslav society are multinational and multiethnic in their very essence, its political and cultural ideology ought to be broad enough to address and reflect these in the most meaningful fashion" (Misina 217). It is fitting that many of the most influential bands were formed in Sarajevo, which was the most diverse of the Yugoslav cities and populated by Serbs, Croats, and Bosnians alike. With such influence through their art, figures such as those mentioned above were able to bring these issues of politics and culture to the wider "conscience collective" (Misina 222) through pop culture. However, rock 'n' roll failed to spread its message of unity to the 56% of the population who lived in rural areas. Unfortunately, these communities found a strange identity within TurboFolk that incorporated traditional folk music and modern synthesized sounds. Suddenly, a community that was being cast aside in an urbanizing Yugoslavia was finding purpose in a post-Yugoslav Serbia marked by nationalist resurgence.

As Yugoslavia dissolved, so did the innocence and comradery of the music industry. Very quickly, what was thought of as "music of 'peasants' and the sounds of the 'Orient'" (Cvoro 7) dominated in nightclubs and in pop culture. TurboFolk was often funded by the Serbian mafias, which were largely groups and individuals guilty of terrible war crimes and often celebrated for it. It was difficult for musicians to resist these themes of "hatred for other ethnic groups [...] or becoming affiliated with the nationalist elites" as it "became a lucrative business" (Halilovich 194). Others completely embraced this shift and their new role as "the new regime's powerful weapon" (Slavkova 424). Most notably Svetlana Veličković, more popularly known as Ceca, who was involved with and eventually married warlord and "right-wing politician Željko Ražnatović-Arkan" (Momčilović 155). Her music encompasses all those things that make TurboFolk incredibly hard to support in hindsight. Her "songs had references to erotic metaphors of masochism connected with militant ideas (e.g., 'Kad bi bio ranjen, krvi bih ti dala' ('If you were wounded, I would give you my blood')). But even when these connotations were less implicit, they still promoted nationalistic and militant values" (Halilovich 195). More explicitly, the genocide of Bosniaks in Srebrenica was a recurring spotlight of songs with the intentions of promoting Serbian superiority and nationalism during the reign of Slobodan Milosevic (Serbian President from 1989-1997). The songs not only "mock [the] victims" but go as far as making the space for those responsible for the genocide to "no longer [...] deny the killings, but actively [...] glorify and celebrate their genocidal deeds and humiliate the survivors" (Halilovich 200).

It comes as no surprise that such vulgar ideas spread like wildfire in a place where people's identities were disbanded. Though most people resisted admitting to enjoying the genre, it continued to rise in popularity and is still one of the leading genres in most of the ex-Yugoslav territories. There was something within TurboFolk that many Balkan people gravitated towards.

Similar to our discussion of ‘Sad’ music in class, there is no pinpointing what about the tacky genre resonated so deeply with the public. In Uros Cvoro’s book, *TurboFolk Music and Cultural Representation of National Identity in Former Yugoslavia*, he conducts a series of interviews with self-proclaimed fans of the genre and receives a plethora of feedback along the lines of “it helps me get over hard times” and “it speaks to my soul” (Cvoro 7). In a time and place of cruelty and economic disaster, there was a desire for escape. The superficial and unintelligent lyrics mixed with a familiar sound really resonated with the population. Interestingly enough, the opposite trend was seen in America: the nineties brought about a booming economy, but sad, slower-tempoed music topped charts. Once again, people resonated with the ‘emotional escape.’

Continuing the discussion we began in class, we cannot make conclusions about what large groups of people gravitate towards, especially in the arts, without looking at the environment in which they are living. There is not something in our biology that is to blame for the human pull towards patriotism in times of cultural crises or a desire to channel deeper emotions, but rather a sociological explanation. Cvoro explains that this enjoyment of TurboFolk is granted to “the nexus of cultural mythologies that have generated perceptions of turbo-folk, while accounting for the malleability of those perceptions, which range from politically charged self-exoticisation, to self-victimisation, to self-empowering defiance. This can include the perception of turbo-folk as… the ‘Balkan Ghost’” (Cvoro 5). This is further proven by the popularity of the genre in Croatia and Bosnia as well. Cvoro goes as far as to say that TurboFolk “effectively acts as a cultural form of reconciliation” (Cvoro 2).

People of the region struggle to define TurboFolk as one thing. On paper, TurboFolk is a high-tempo synthesized version of pop music that utilizes traditional folk instrumentation of the Balkan regions; however, it is so much more than that. It seems that artists were labeled as

TurboFolk, which is what made their music that, rather than the other way around. Lots of genres in this time followed similar trends in music, such as faster rhythm and traditional instruments, but the ideologies of the artists are what separated a song from being TurboFolk or not. Expat Serbians who left as Yugoslavia dismantled refused to support a regime willing to brutally murder civilians who were once considered their comrades, and thus are ashamed of the genre and themes that are brought up between the lines. On the other hand, many of those who stayed were able to accept the genre, especially as it evolved to what is now considered the more modern version: PopFolk. The two are mainly distinguished by "the year 2000 and the political overthrow of Milosevic through mass protests in Serbia" (Cvoro 13). They saw this as an escape from their reality, a means to get by.

Most anybody would agree that TurboFolk is considered a techno-fied version of the folk genre. One of its main characteristics is the fast tempos meant for the clubs and dancing. I wanted to test whether this fast tempo was truly characteristic of TurboFolk or is a plethora of genres, using A/B testing by using NumPy as a package in the data science library here at Berkeley. The Foundational Data Science class, Data 8, teaches the version of NumPy that I used in this analysis. My null hypothesis is that TurboFolk does not have a faster average BPM (beats per minute) than other genres of Serbian and Yugoslav music. In other words, the average BPM of TurboFolk has the same distribution as the other genres. My alternative hypothesis is that TurboFolk average BPM does not have the same underlying distribution as other genres and that TurboFolk actually has on average a faster BPM.

To begin, I used a Spotify playlist called "Serbian Turbo-Folk" and added songs I knew fell within the genre, as well as songs referenced in the research for this paper. I used the new Spotify 'mix' feature to easily access the BPM for each song. I then repeated this with a separate

playlist mainly featuring Yugoslav Rock ‘n’ Roll (I have many playlists that feature this genre) and added to it Narodna Muzika (a genre of Serbian music that roughly translates to national music), 80s Pop, Folklore music (songs used to dance Kolo), and two newer Sevdalinka (traditional folk) albums. This way my ‘other’ genre featured a wide variety of rhythms and tempos.

In Jupyter, I imported the necessary tools for my analysis and began by constructing my table which featured two columns: Label and BPM. The first 81 rows were the BPM of the songs randomly selected from my TurboFolk playlist, and the next 135 were those in the ‘other’ group. The average BPM of these two groups were 136.38 and 124.41, respectively, with an observed difference of approximately 11.97. Because my alternate hypothesis implies directionality (TurboFolk is faster), it is important that we do not use the absolute difference but subtract the other average BPM from the TurboFolk average BPM each time. This became my observed statistic that I plan to compare against a plethora of differences under the hypothesis that the average BPM should be the same regardless of genre.

I went ahead and ran 1,000 permutations of my sample by using a for loop. Each iteration, I reshuffled the labeled column without replacement (to keep the proportion of TurboFolk to other songs consistent). Then I found the difference between the new average ‘TurboFolk’ BPM and the new average ‘other’ BPM. All the test statistics were tracked in an array which had a length of 1,000 elements (one for each shuffle). Under the null hypothesis, we expect our test statistics to create a normal distribution centered around zero (where the average BPM for both genres is the same). The test statistics ranged from around -12 to 12 and calculated a p-value of 0.002 for our observed statistic. That means that only 0.2% of the time did we see a difference greater than the one we observed under the hypothesis that TurboFolk and other genres have the

same average BPM. Since this is a very rare observation, we can reject our null hypothesis with a p-cutoff as low as 1%. Often a p-cutoff of 1-5% is used to reject the null hypothesis, so we can be fairly confident that our alternative is true: TurboFolk has a higher average BPM than that of other genres in the ex-Yugoslav region.

Interestingly enough, when looking at the minimum, first quartile, median, third quartile, maximum, and IQR of the two groups, we see other genres having a wider range of tempos, with a min of 65 BPM and a max as high as 208 BPM, though its IQR (33.5) is only slightly larger than TurboFolk's (30). In contrast with TurboFolk, which is more restricted with a range between 93-198 BPM. The min, first quartile, median, and third quartile are slower for other genres than TurboFolk (28, 14, 13, and 10.5 BPM), while the max (in our sample) is 10 BPM faster.

In order to improve my test, I would increase my sample size. Having access to a larger database of songs that are more accurately labeled as TurboFolk would also improve my results. From my research, it seems that TurboFolk can be a bit subjective, so making sure songs within this genre were released in the 90s. Along with this, compared to a wider variety of other genres including more modern music that doesn't fall into the PopFolk category.

In future versions of this A/B test, I would like to see how songs released in different years compare in BPM for just TurboFolk or specific other genres: for example, whether rock released in the 90s had a faster tempo than rock released earlier. It would be interesting to see whether the TurboFolk boom in Serbia was more impactful on Rock 'n' Roll or slowing down the music we saw in America at the same time. Because of the ambiguity of what exactly makes a song TurboFolk, it would be interesting to look into ML algorithms to categorize music and see whether BPM would be one of the main features used in this categorization.

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